

1870–1900

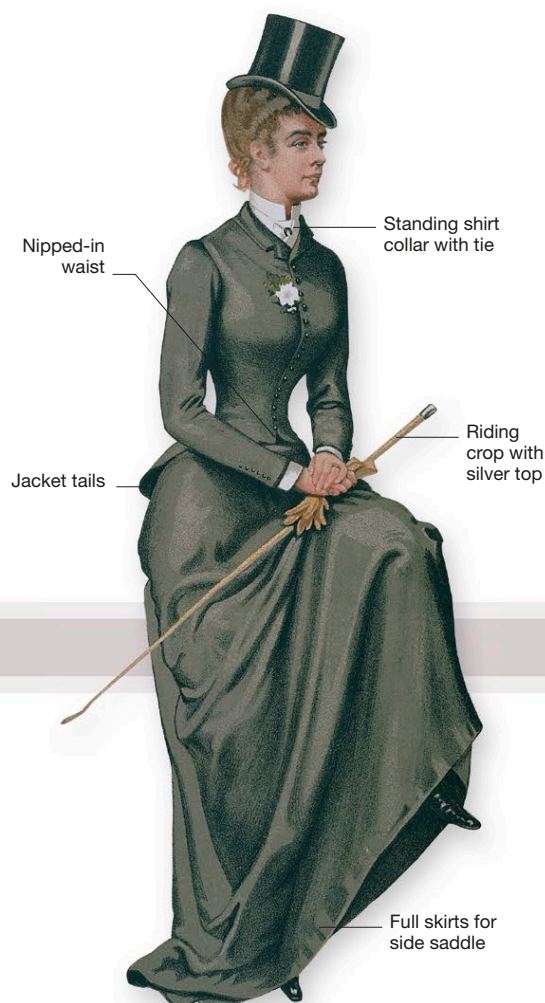
SPORTSWEAR FOR THE NEW WOMAN

Women's daywear was adapted for sports from archery to croquet and boating to tennis, while still preserving a fashionable waistline, sleeve shape, and skirt fullness. Drawers worn under petticoats enabled freedom of movement without fear of embarrassment. Knitted underclothing such as Dr Jaeger's sanitary underwear, available from the mid-1880s, cotton combination garments that avoided bulky waists, and specifically designed sporting corsets were a boon. The breathable cotton-mesh fabric Aertex was invented in 1888, and less restrictive corsets were made that incorporated this mesh to allow better air flow. Women supporters of the Pre-Raphaelite and Aesthetic movements had already left off corsets and wire understructures. While the new woman spurned fancy fabrics, burgeoning department stores sold silk brocades and plush velvet gowns in joyful colours, and society women found themselves spoilt for choice.

ARTISTIC AND AESTHETIC



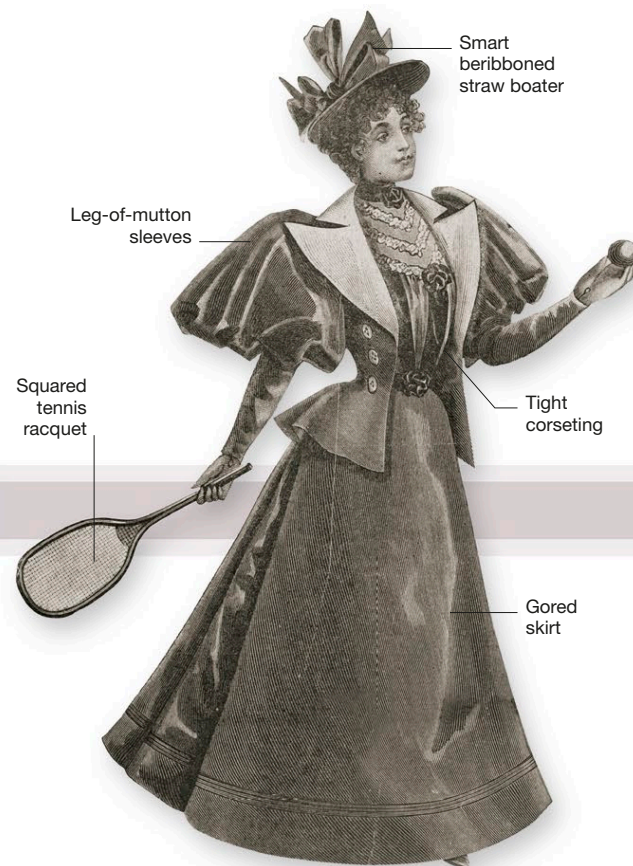
Women in artistic circles, such as the Pre-Raphaelite muse Jane Morris, flouted rigid dress conventions, pioneering a freer style. Dress reform societies also campaigned for healthier, less structured forms of dress. Their dress styles recalled medieval (pre-hooped skirt) days. They borrowed relaxed styles such as the early sack back, in which fabric fell unfettered from nape to hem.



Riding habit Made of soft wool, this jacket has a long row of tiny buttons to fasten tightly over a corset. Riding tails sat neatly upon late 1880s bustles. The top hat perches high on the crown on frizzed hair.



Bustle dress This sensible wool dress in brown, c.1870–75, was suitable for country walking, travelling, croquet, archery, and picnicking, all popular female pursuits. Going-away outfits were often of a similar style and colour.



Lawn tennis dress Although earlier tennis dresses (c.1875–85) had aprons with pockets for the balls, this 1897 fashion advertisement for the new season offers little concession to sport. *Punch* magazine joked that women should have a handicap.